coursera | MoMA

What Is Contemporary Art?

Today's goal • 3/3 items

Module 1
Introduction to What Is Contemporary Art?

Module 2
Media from Television to the Internet

Module 3
Territories & Transit

Module 4
Materials & Making

Module 5
Agency

Visibility
- Introduction to Module 5
  Reading • 10 min
- Pope.L's New York crawls
  Reading • 10 min
- In New York City with Pope.L | Direct action
  Video • 4 min
- Two artists consider Catherine Opie, Dyke, 1993
  Video • 2 min
- Tania Bruguera on Untitled (Havana, 2000), 2000
  Video • 4 min
- Luis Camnitzer on Memorial, 2009
  Video • 2 min
- Yara Said on the Refugee Flag, 2016
  Reading • 10 min
- Firelei Báez on For Améthyste and Athénaïre (Exiled Muses Beyond Jean Luc Nancy's Canon), Anacaonas, 2018
  Reading • 10 min

Voice
- Who speaks?
  Reading • 10 min
- Nick Cave on Soundsuit, 2011
  Video • 2 min
- Lawrence Abu Hamdan, Conflicted Phonemes, 2012
  Reading • 10 min
- P Staff on Weed Killer, 2017
  Reading • 10 min

Action
- Taking action
  Reading • 10 min
- Lorraine O'Grady on Mlle Bourgeoise Noire, 1980–83/2009
  Video • 2 min
- Xiao Lu on Dialogue, 1989
  Video • 2 min
- Ralph Borland, Suited for Subversion (Prototype), 2002
  Video • 1 min
- Defining and blurring identities through performance
  Reading • 10 min

Review & Respond
- Memory Check
  Practice Assignment • Grade: 80%
- Reflect on Agency in Module 5
  Dialogue • 15 min
- Optional Readings & Resources
  Reading • 10 min

Module 6
Power

Exposing Power
- Introduction to Module 6
  Reading • 10 min
- Instructor Christian Rattemeyer on Mark Lombardi's diagrams of power
  Video • 6 min
- What do war and peace have to do with chandeliers and portraits?
  Reading • 10 min
- Deana Lawson on Nation, 2017
  Video • 2 min

Abuse of Power
- How do artists critique power?
  Reading • 10 min
- **Two responses to abuse of power**
  Reading • 10 min
- Wolfgang Tillmans on Sendeschluss / End of Broadcast I, 2014
  Video • 2 min

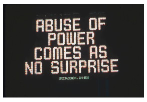
Sources of Power
- Power: sources and resources
  Reading • 10 min
- Outer space to inner earth
  Reading • 10 min
- Curator Paola Antonelli on Massoud Hassani's Mine Kafon wind-powered deminer, 2011
  Video • 1 min
- Rania Ghosn on After Oil, 2016
  Video • 4 min

Review & Respond
- Memory Check
  Practice Assignment
- Reflecting on Power in Art
  Dialogue • 15 min
- Final course reflection
  Graded Assignment • 30 min
- Optional Readings & Resources
  Reading • 10 min
- End-of-course survey
  Reading • 5 min
- Recordings of live virtual sessions (optional)
  Reading • 10 min
- MoMA Resources
  Reading • 10 min

Two responses to abuse of power

0:01 / 3:04 1x

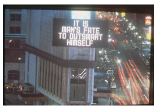
Jenny Holzer, *Abuse of Power Comes As No Surprise* from the series Truisms, 1980–present



Installation view, *Jenny Holzer: Messages to the Public*, Times Square, New York, March 1–31, 1982. © 2019 Jenny Holzer/Artists Rights Society (ARS), New York. Courtesy Public Art Fund, NY

Jenny Holzer works with words: scrolling across LED signs, projected onto buildings, and printed on T-shirts, to name only some of her formats. The sentence emblazoned on this jumbo sign in Times Square, *ABUSE OF POWER COMES AS NO SURPRISE*, first appeared in a list of Truisms that Holzer wrote in 1977, made into posters, and pasted around Manhattan. These statements range from witty (*ELABORATION IS A FORM OF POLLUTION*) to poetic (*ALL THINGS ARE DELICATELY INTERCONNECTED*) to dark (*EVEN YOUR FAMILY CAN BETRAY YOU*).

Holzer is interested in drawing our attention to the many struggles and complexities of being human, including our power dynamics. Putting forward a variety of perspectives, she aims to move and provoke. By placing phrases on everyday items or screens normally reserved for advertisements, she co-opts common marketing strategies and sends her messages far out into the world.



Installation view, *Jenny Holzer: Messages to the Public*, Times Square, New York, March 1–31, 1982. © 2019 Jenny Holzer/Artists Rights Society (ARS), New York. Courtesy Public Art Fund, NY

Chto Delat (What is to be done?), *The Excluded. In a Moment of Danger*, 2014

But nobody controls the situation as a whole.

Chto Delat (What is to be done?). Still from *The Excluded. In a Moment of Danger*. 2014. Four-channel video (color, sound), 56:46 min. The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Fund for the Twenty-First Century. © 2019 Chto Delat (What is to be done?). Courtesy the artists

In 2003, a group of Russian artists, critics, philosophers, and writers formed Chto Delat (What is to be done?), a collective that tries to answer that question through a range of creative work tackling social and political issues. Eleven years into their project, as discrimination against LGBTQ+ people spiked and Russia increased its political-military pressure on Ukraine, Chto Delat declared failure: "What can be done with this state of affairs?….We lost. But we are prepared to learn from our mistakes."

To take stock and re-empower themselves, they made a four-channel, 12-chapter video called, *The Excluded. In a Moment of Danger*. In a spare room furnished with blocks doubling as seats and pedestals, a group of graduates from Chto Delat's educational initiative, the School of Engaged Art, analyze their defeat. They convey their increasingly marginalized, precarious position in society through monologues directly addressing viewers and in performances laced with absurdity, contextualizing their struggle within a long chain of related fights for fairness, peace, and unity.

Watch ***The Excluded. In a Moment of Danger.***

Mark as completed

Like Dislike Report an issue

Go to next item →